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Dear Editors,

I am pleased to submit the enclosed manuscript, “Ninety-Three Per Cent of a Backlog Is Not a Backlog: Reading a Public Publisher’s Own Quality Signal,” for consideration as a Research Paper in *Government Information Quarterly*.

The United Kingdom’s official legislation service publishes, per Act and machine-readably, the amendments it has not yet applied to the text it displays. Read as a backlog — the reading the flag invites — there are 14,407 of them across the Public General Acts of 1988–2026. That reading overstates by a factor of 131. Ninety-three per cent are enacted but not commenced; a further 901 carry a commencement date still in the future; and the service is right to apply neither. What remains is 99 effects in 9 Acts, none unapplied longer than 21 days against a published three-month target. The service meets its own standard without exception.

The contribution is not that finding but the error that produced it. This study first recorded the 14,407 figure as a backlog, and an independent verification script agreed. Everything needed to read the record correctly was published all along — but the flag inviting the wrong conclusion is an attribute on each effect, while the fact correcting it is a child element inside it, and the publisher’s own prose covers all four states with one term. A consumer who parses attributes and reads the documentation is not merely unaided; he is confirmed in a false accusation against a service doing its job. The transferable claim is that publishing a distinguishing fact is not sufficient: its placement decides what most readers conclude.

I believe this fits the journal’s scope directly. It is a study of how the structure of published government information shapes what its users conclude, measured on a national service rather than argued in principle, and its recommendations are addressed to publishers of official data.

The manuscript is prepared for double anonymized review: the title page is supplied as a separate file, and the manuscript file carries no author identification in its text, its LaTeX source, or its PDF metadata. The collection, the analysis, the verification scripts and every figure are openly available; the repository address names me, so it is given on the title page rather than in the manuscript.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration elsewhere. There are no competing interests and no funding to declare. I am the sole author. A declaration of generative AI use is included with the declarations on the title page.

Thank you for your consideration.

Yours sincerely,

Abdullah Almohammed